A Science Fiction Book Wins the Booker Prize for the First Time

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For the first time ever, a science fiction book has won the Booker Prize. M. John Harrison's The End of Everything won the 2026 prize. The Booker Prize is one of the most famous awards for books written in English and published in the United Kingdom or Ireland.

The win **crowns** Harrison's 60-year **career**. His first short story came out in 1966. He is seen as one of the most **original** voices in British fantasy and science fiction.

The book is set on England's south coast after a strange disaster. Its hero, Philip Tennent, moved from London to the small town of Dalston-on-Sea. London was taken over by strange, **short-lived beings** called the iGhetti. Nobody knows if they are really aliens. Tennent earns money by finding alien objects on the beach and selling them. Then something stranger appears: a baby-like creature that keeps growing and learning. Tennent and his aunt Marnie just want to get rid of it.

In 2007, Harrison won the Arthur C. Clarke Award and the Philip K. Dick Award for his book Nova Swing.

Word Treasure

crowns -- To finish something in the best possible way, like putting a crown on it.
short-lived -- Something that does not live or last for very long.
beings -- Living things, like people or creatures.
original -- New and different from anything before.
career -- All the work someone does in their job over many years.

Background you need

The Booker Prize is one of the most famous awards for books written in English and published in the United Kingdom or Ireland.

Science fiction is a kind of story that imagines strange new worlds, science, or the future.

This is the first time a science fiction book has won the Booker Prize, and the win crowns M. John Harrison's 60-year career.

Break it down

WHO: Author M. John Harrison and his book's hero, Philip Tennent.
WHAT: Harrison's science fiction book The End of Everything won the Booker Prize.
WHERE: The book is set on England's south coast, in the small town of Dalston-on-Sea.
WHY: It is the first time a science fiction book has won this famous book award.

Why it matters

It shows that the stories you love, like tales about aliens and strange worlds, can win the biggest book prizes too.

Test what you remember

1. Which book won the 2026 Booker Prize?

- (A) The End of Everything
- (B) Dalston-on-Sea
- (C) Nova Swing
- (D) The iGhetti

2. Who wrote the winning book?

- (A) Philip Tennent
- (B) Philip K. Dick
- (C) M. John Harrison
- (D) Arthur C. Clarke

3. What is special about this win?

- (A) It is the first book ever written
- (B) It is the first book set in London
- (C) It is the first book to win two awards
- (D) It is the first time a science fiction book has won the Booker Prize

4. Where is the book set?

- (A) On England's south coast
- (B) In New York City
- (C) In the mountains of Scotland
- (D) On the Moon

5. How does Philip Tennent earn money?

- (A) By writing short stories
- (B) By selling tickets to a show
- (C) By working in a rocket factory
- (D) By finding alien objects on the beach and selling them

6. What does Tennent want to do with the baby-like creature?

- (A) Keep it as a pet
- (B) Teach it to read
- (C) Get rid of it
- (D) Take it to London

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: D 4: A 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):